Back came the doctor. He had called an ambulance and off I went to a small local hospital. It was the first time in my life (and the only time so far) that I was in an ambulance, and the first time I was in a hospital as a patient.

There they gave me a hefty shot of morphine, and in a little while the pain left. More than the pain left. All my. troubles, all my concerns,

11 Had I reported the pain to a competent doctor two years before, and had it been diagnosed, I could have taken appropriate preventive measures—making certain I drank two quarts of water a day—and would then probably have prevented the much greater agony now.

all my worries left. I lay there, I remember, facing the wall, in complete peace. It wasn't euphoria; it was better than euphoria; it was quiet, calm nirvana. I didn't feel bored. I didn't have to think. I just lay there at rest. Neither before nor since have I ever felt so free of all the endless indignities of life.

Gertrude sat at the bedside and I, with my back to her, felt her holding my hand. I don't know how much time passed, but a nurse came in and asked Gertrude if she would care to eat and assured her I would be all right. Gertrude left. I did not know this at the time; Gertrude told me of it afterward. All I know was that after a while, I was conscious that Gertrude was not holding my hand. I wondered if she were still there, but it seemed too much trouble to turn around. I felt only the smallest, most distant pang of regret at the thought that she might not be there, and then I let that go, too.

The memory of that one time under morphine convinces me that I will have to be under equivalent pain before I ever accept another shot. That feeling of ultimate peace, if experienced just a few times, would have an attraction I couldn't resist and I would be an addict. Fortunately, I have never had to accept another shot.

By dinnertime I was myself, sufficiently myself to be apprehensive that the pain would return, but it did not. While I was sedated, the kidney stone stopped doing whatever it had been doing to cause the pain.

They fed me, to my great satisfaction. I am very fortunate that I like food, for though people complain bitterly about banquet food and hospital food, for instance, I find them good. (There's always the memory of the Navy Yard cafeteria, of course, but that was exceptional.)

Then, just before I was expected to fall asleep, they brought me another glass